him, Ratan did not shy away from media glare and asserted his right as a citizen of the country. Chandrasekhar had sent an open letter to Ratan as well as media companies wanting to know why the Tatas had chosen Radia to head their PR.

Ratan asserted that the group had been targeted by campaigns driven by an unholy nexus between certain corporates and the media through selected journalists. He further added, 'As [the] Tatas did not enjoy any such "captive connections" in this environment, the Tata Group had no option but to seek an external agency focused at projecting its point of view in the media and countering the misinformation and vested interest viewpoints which were being expressed.'

The tape leaks even disturbed Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. In an official statement telecast on the national Doordarshan News, he said: 'I am aware of the nervousness in some sections of the corporate sector as I think out of the powers conferred upon governmental authorities to tap telephones for protecting national security and preventing tax evasion and money laundering … [The powers of tapping] have to be exercised with utmost care and under well-defined rules, procedures and mechanisms so that they are not misused.'

In the meantime, investigations by central agencies continued. On 2 February 2011, the CBI arrested Telecom Minister A. Raja on charges of corruption. On 10 February, the Supreme Court issued orders to the CBI to investigate business corporations that were beneficiaries of the 2G spectrum allocation. On the apex court's directions, in March 2011, the Centre established a special court to hear 2G cases.

In the midst of these developments, Ratan's privacy concerns found favourable resonance within the business community and outside. Senior politicians such as Farooq Abdullah, Sharad Pawar and Kapil Sibal decried the attacks on the corporates and called for an end to the 'corporate witch hunting'. Abdullah said, 'If a person like Ratan Tata feels [he is a victim of witch hunting] it is a concern for us', and Pawar echoed similar sentiments commenting, 'When a person like him [Tata] makes a statement, I think we should take him seriously.'

In view of the importance of the issue, India's Parliamentary Public Accounts Committee (PAC), headed by Murli Manohar Joshi, decided to hear the 2G allocation matter. As part of the hearing, on 4 April 2011, Ratan and Radia were summoned for questioning.